Magdalena Wasilewska

University of Amsterdam, Office E7.04, Roetersstraat 11, 1018 WB Amsterdam
+48 665 843 925 · m.j.wasilewska@uva.nl · sites.google.com/view/magdalena-wasilewska

Education

University of Amsterdam — Amsterdam, the Netherlands
PhD in Economics, Department of Microeconomics, CREED — September 2023 – present

- Supervisors: Prof. dr. Joël van der Weele and dr. Thomas Douenne
- Research stay at FAIR, NHH (hosted by Prof. Bertil Tungodden), February – April 2026

KU Leuven — Leuven, Belgium
MSc in Sociology (Social Data Science) — 2022 – 2023

University of Amsterdam — Amsterdam, the Netherlands
MSc in Economics (Behavioural Economics and Game Theory) — 2021 – 2022

Warsaw School of Economics — Warsaw, Poland
BSc in Quantitative Methods in Economics and Information Systems — 2017 – 2020

Research Interests

Behavioral Economics, Experimental Economics, Public Economics, Political Economy

References

Prof. Joël van der Weele
University of Amsterdam
j.j.vanderweele@uva.nl

dr. Thomas Douenne
University of Amsterdam
t.r.g.r.douenne@uva.nl

Prof. Bertil Tungodden
Norwegian School of Economics
bertil.tungodden@nhh.no

Placement Director
Prof. Eric Bartelsman
e.j.bartelsman@vu.nl
+31 (0)20 598 6167

Job Market Paper

Fairness at a Price: Support for Complex Benefit Systems

Complex benefit systems more accurately target those viewed as deserving, but make benefits costly to claim and keep. I study people's willingness to impose costs on claimants to improve targeting accuracy in pursuit of fairness. In an experiment, spectators choose between two systems, each distributing eight extra payments among twelve workers. One system more accurately targets workers affected by an earnings shock, but requires unpaid effort from recipients. The other requires no effort but is less accurate. Across treatments, I vary the properties of the accurate system. Fewer spectators choose the accurate system when effort costs are higher. Yet most impose effort costs of a combined 56 minutes to accurately target one additional payment, worth seven minutes of pay. Spectators place a premium on reaching every intended recipient: fewer choose the accurate system when it misses one affected worker, even though its targeting advantage is unchanged. In a survey experiment with 2,728 Dutch respondents, I examine how information about the costs of complexity affects support for simpler benefits. Like impartial spectators, non-recipients of benefits respond to costs: they become more supportive of simplification once informed. Recipients do not, despite equally inaccurate priors and similar belief updating. These findings inform the political economy of simplification reforms.

Working Papers

Do People Distinguish Income from Wealth Inequality? Evidence from the Netherlands
with Thomas Douenne, Oda Sund, and Joël van der Weele · ***R&R at The Economic Journal***

In most countries, wealth inequality is much higher than income inequality, spurring debates about wealth taxation. We study people's perceptions of income and wealth inequality using a survey-experiment linked to administrative records for the Dutch population. We document a strong overlap in perceptions about the two distributions: people largely underestimate the difference between the respective levels of inequality and use information about income (inequality, own rank) to predict wealth and vice versa, even when information about both is provided. Informing people about inequality or their own rank has direct effects on their beliefs, but little effect on their policy preferences.

Work in Progress

Inequality Narratives and Redistribution
with Thomas Douenne, Oda Sund, and Joël van der Weele

How do people explain economic inequality, and how do these personal narratives shape responses to narratives provided by others? We field two linked surveys on representative samples of the Dutch population, conducted two years apart and linked to administrative tax data, and document three findings. First, open-ended "top-of-mind" explanations show that most respondents attribute inequality to structural factors (the labor market, family background, education, and the tax system) rather than effort or luck, and that these narratives vary with wealth, political identity, and fairness views. Second, linking the surveys, narratives independently predict redistributive preferences two years later, as well as which narratives respondents expose themselves to when given a choice. Third, experimentally provided narratives shift emotions and beliefs about the meritocracy of education, but not redistributive attitudes; updating is constrained by prior beliefs, and counter-attitudinal expert narratives can even backfire. Inequality narratives are thus durable elements of worldviews, robust to short-run interventions.

Institutions and Meritocracy

Teaching and Supervision

Economics (in a Global Business World) 2023 – present
Teaching Assistant, BSc Business Administration, University of Amsterdam

Master and Bachelor Thesis Supervision 2023 – present
20 BSc theses (Economics and Business Economics; PPLE), 1 MSc thesis (Economics)

Grants

Fairness at a Price: Support for Complex Benefit Systems
Amsterdam Center for Behavioral Change (ACBC) €10 000
A Sustainable Future (ASF) Initiative €9 200
Amsterdam Centre for European Studies (ACES) €2 500

Inequality Narratives and Redistribution (with T. Douenne, O. Sund and J. van der Weele)
LISS panel grant (Principal Investigator) approx. €10 000
Amsterdam Center for Behavioral Change (ACBC) approx. €7 000

Do People Distinguish Income from Wealth Inequality? (with T. Douenne, O. Sund and J. van der Weele)
Amsterdam Centre for European Studies (ACES) approx. €5 000

Presentations

2026: 18th Nordic Conference in Behavioral and Experimental Economics, Helsinki; World Inequality Conference, Paris; BÆM Meeting on Fairness in the Economy, Bristol; Bergen-Berlin Behavioural Workshop, Bergen; Pizza & Presentation Seminar, FAIR NHH, Bergen

2025: Workshop on Psychological and Economic Perspectives on Inequality, Amsterdam; Workshop in Behavioral Public Economics and Political Economy, Vienna; Narratives, Memory and Beliefs Summer School and Workshop, Riederau; Text as Data in Behavioral Economics, Potsdam; CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting (CCC), Amsterdam; MPI-CREED Meeting, Bonn

2024: Interdisciplinary Brownbag Seminar of Behavioral Sciences, Maastricht; Max Planck Summer School on the Political Economy of Conflict and Redistribution, Berlin; 23rd Journées Louis-André Gérard-Varet (LAGV), Marseille; 7th Maastricht Behavioral Economic Policy Symposium (M-BEPS), Maastricht; CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting (CCC), Norwich

Service

- Organiser of the CREED lunch seminar
- Co-organiser of the CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting

Skills

Languages Polish (native), English (fluent), French (beginner), Dutch (beginner)
Software Stata, R, Python, LaTeX